Direct & Indirect Speech

In French, direct speech OR discours direct is when we directly quote someone's words or statements. For example, if someone says, "I am going to the park," and you repeat their exact words, it would be direct speech. It's like quoting them directly, using quotation marks.

Indirect speech OR discours indirect, on the other hand, is when we report or convey what someone said without using their exact words. Instead of quoting them directly, we paraphrase or summarise their statement. For example, if someone says, "I am going to the park," and you say, "They said they are going to the park," it would be indirect speech.

To summarise:

- Direct speech involves using someone's exact words and putting them in quotation marks.
- Indirect speech involves reporting or summarising what someone said without using their exact words.

Both direct and indirect speech are commonly used in writing and conversation to relay what someone has said.

Direct Speech

Français	English
Kiran dit : « Je n'aime pas l'humour de JM. »	Kiran says, “I don't like JM’s humour.”
Sophia répond : « Je suis malade. »	Sophia responds, “I am sick.”
« Steven ne sait pas où il gardait ses clés » dit Marc.	“Steven doesn’t know where he put his keys,” says Marc.

Note: in English we use the quotation marks **“ ”** , in French we use the **guillemets** «»

Indirect Speech

In indirect speech, generally the original quote is reported using a conjunction (e.g. **que**) or a connector **+ dependent clause**

We remove the quotation marks when constructing a sentence in indirect speech.

Let's take the same above examples in indirect speech.

Français	English
Kiran dit qu'elle n'aime pas l'humour de JM.	Kiran says that she doesn't like JM's humour.
Sophia répond qu'elle est malade.	Sophia responds that she is sick.
Marc dit qu'il ne sait pas où Steven gardait ses clés.	Marc says that he doesn't know where Steven put his keys.

Note: It's important to note that the pronouns in the sentence may also change based on the perspective of the speaker.

For example…

Direct Speech	Indirect Speech
Elle a répondu : « Non, **je** ne l'ai pas vu depuis l'heure du déjeuner. » She responded, "No, I haven't seen him since lunchtime."	Elle a répondu qu'**elle** ne l'avait pas vu depuis l'heure du déjeuner. She responded that she hadn't seen him since lunchtime.
Le patron a crié : « **Ton** rapport est incomplet ! » The boss shouted, "Your report is incomplete!"	Le patron a crié que **mon** rapport était incomplet The boss shouted that my report was incomplete.
Ray a dit : « **J**'ai déjà quitté la gare. » Ray said, "I already left the station."	Ray a dit qu'**il** avait déjà quitté la gare. Ray said that he had already left the station.

Note: Verb conjugations need to agree with the new subject. In direct speech, the words of the speaker are recounted as they are with no modification. However, in indirect speech, the subject is modified and so is the conjugation of the verb.

Direct Speech	Indirect Speech
Elle dit : « J'ai mal à la tête. » She says, "I have a headache."	Elle dit qu'elle a mal à la tête. She says that she has a headache.
« Il pleut depuis cet après-midi », rapportent-ils. "It's been raining since this afternoon," they reported.	Ils ont rapporté qu'il pleut depuis cet après-midi-là. They reported that it's been raining since that afternoon.

Balancing Tenses: La Concordance des temps

- When the verb in the main clause is in the present tense, the tense of the reported sentence does not change.
- However, when the main clause is in the past tense, the verb tense of the reported sentence needs to be changed.

If the main clause is in the past:

Français	English
Present	Imparfait
Passé composé	Plus-que-parfait
Futur	Present Conditional
Futur Antérieur	Past Conditional
Imperative	Verb + de + infinitive
Imparfait	Imparfait
Conditional, Subjunctive	Conditional, Subjunctive

Present → Imparfait

Direct Speech	Indirect Speech
Yannis a déclaré : « Je quitte la maison de mes parents. » Yannis declared "I am leaving my parents' house."	Yannis a déclaré qu'il quittait la maison de ses parents. Yannis declared that he was leaving his parents' house
Quand il a téléphoné, il a dit : « Je suis à l'aéroport. » When he called, he said, "I'm at the airport."	Quand il a téléphoné, il a dit qu'il était à l'aéroport. When he called, he said he was at the airport.
Agathe m'a dit : « Tu es bête. » Agatha told me, "You're stupid."	Agathe m'a dit que j'étais bête. Agatha told me that I was stupid.

Passé Composé → Plus-que-Parfait

Direct Speech	Indirect Speech
Akshata nous a raconté « Je me suis fait arnaquer. » Akshata told us, "I got ripped off"	Akshata nous a raconté qu'elle s'était fait arnaquer. Akshata told us that she had been ripped off.
Il a raconté : « Elle a été très gentille avec moi. » He said, “She was very kind to me.”	Il a raconté qu’elle avait été très gentille avec lui. He said that she had been very kind to him.
Il a affirmé : « Je l’ai reconnue tout de suite. » He said, "I recognized her right away."	Il a affirmé qu’il l’avait reconnue tout de suite. He said he had recognized her right away.

Futur → Present Conditional

Direct Speech	Indirect Speech
AB a annoncé : « Je ne veux plus aller au Canada, je m’installerai au Japon. » AB announced, “I don't want to go to Canada anymore, I will settle in Japan.”	AB a annoncé qu'il ne voulait plus aller au Canada et qu'il s'installerait au Japon. AB announced that he no longer wanted to go to Canada and that would settle in Japan
JM a raconté au cours : « Un jour, je deviendrai un scénariste célèbre. » JM recounted in class, “One day, I’ll become a famous screenwriter.”	JM a raconté au cours qu’un jour, il deviendrait un scénariste célèbre. JM recounted in class that, one day, he would become a famous screenwriter.
Elle a dit : « Je serai à l’heure. » She said, “I’ll be on time.”	Elle a dit qu’elle serait à l’heure. She said she would be on time.

Imparfait → Imparfait

Direct Speech	Indirect Speech
Marie a avoué : « Je n'aimais pas mon mari, en fait. »	Marie a avoué qu'elle n'aimait pas son mari.

Marie confessed, "I did not love my husband, in fact."	Marie confessed that she did not love her husband.
Pierre a dit : « Je voulais parler à ma mère. » Pierre said, “I wanted to talk to my mother.”	Pierre a dit qu’il voulait parler à sa mère. Pierre said that he wanted to talk to his mother.
« J’étais jeune quand ce s’est arrivé, » je lui ai dit “I was young when it happened,” I told her.	Je lui ai dit que j’étais jeune quand ça s'est arrivé. I told her that I was young when it happened.

Conditional, Subjunctive → Conditional, Subjunctive

Direct Speech	Indirect Speech
Le parlement a révélé : « La session serait annulée. » The parliament revealed, "The session would be canceled"	Le parlement a révélé que la session serait annulée. Parliament revealed that the session would be canceled.
Il explique : « Je viendrais, mais j’ai du travail à faire. » He explains, "I would come, but I have work to do."	Il explique qu’il viendrait, mais, il a du travail à faire. He explains that he would come, but he has work to do.
Elle a crié : « Je veux que tu restes loin de moi. » She yelled, “I want you to stay away from me.”	Elle a crié qu’elle voulait que tu restes loin d’elle. She yelled that she wanted you to stay away from her.
Il a dit : « Il est impératif que vous arriviez à temps. » He said, "It's imperative that you arrive on time."	Il a dit qu’il était impératif que vous arriviez à temps. He said that it was imperative that you arrive on time.

Reporting Verbs

Reporting verbs are verbs used to report or convey what someone has said. These verbs help to attribute the speech or thoughts to the original speaker. Examples of reporting verbs include:

Français	English
dire	to say, to tell
affirmer	to affirm
annoncer	to announce
avouer	to confess
assurer	to assure
confier	to confide
crier	to scream, to shout
déclarer	to declare
observer	to observe
prétendre	to claim
promettre	to promise
remarquer	to remark, to notice
répondre	to respond
révéler	to reveal

Different Types of Phrases, Different Constructions/Verbs.

To report a Declarative sentence

Use the verb like ***dire* + que** to report a declarative sentence

Other verbs that can be used: **declarer** (to declare), **preciser** (to specify), **annonce**r (to announce), **affirmer** (to state/say), **raconter** (to recount), etc.

Direct Speech	Indirect Speech
Donald déclare « Je suis le meilleur président. » Donald declares, "I'm the best president"	Donald déclare qu'il est le meilleur président. Donald declares that he's the best president.
Les étudiants affirment « Nous allons faire une manifestation contre notre professeur. » Students affirm, "We are going to protest against our teacher"	Les étudiants affirment qu'ils vont faire une manifestation contre leur professeur. The students affirm that they are going to protest against their teacher.

To Report a Sentence in the Imperative Form

To report a sentence in the imperative form, use the verb **demander, conseiller, ordonner + de + (ne pas) infinitive** in the indirect speech.

Direct Speech	Indirect Speech
Marc m'a dit « Ne me dérange pas. » Marc says, "Do not disturb me."	Marc m'a demandé de ne pas le déranger. Marc is asking me not to disturb him.
JM ordonne à Émile « Sortez de la classe. » JM orders Émile, "Get out of the class"	Le chef ordonne à Émile de **sortir** de la classe. The chief orders Émile to leave the class.

To Report Simple Questions

To Report Simple Questions, we use the verb **demander, croire/savoir + si**

Direct Speech	Indirect Speech
Mes collègues me demandent « Tu parles français ? » My colleagues ask me, "Do you speak French?"	Mes collègues me demandent si je parle français. My colleagues ask me if I speak French
Il lui demande : « Croyez-vous que Naomi viendra ? » He asks her, "Do you believe that Naomi is coming?"	Il lui demande si elle croit que Naomi viendrait. He asked her if she believes Naomi would come.

To report a question with an interrogative adverb/adjective

Use demander, **vouloir savoir, se demander + Interrogative** (comment, pourquoi, quand, où, etc.) to report a question in interrogative adverb/adjective.

Direct Speech	Indirect Speech
Quentin demande « **Où** est mon portefeuille ? » Quentin asks, "Where is my wallet?"	Quentin demande **où** est son portefeuille. Quentin asks where his wallet is.
Il m'a demandé « Combien ton sac Birkin a-t-il coûté ? » He asked me, "How much does your Birkin bag cost?"	Il m'a demandé **combien** coûtait mon sac Birkin. He asked me how much my birkin bag cost.

To Report a Question

To Report a Question starting with **"Qu'est-ce que"** , use the verb **demander, se demander, vouloir, savoir + ce que**

Direct Speech	Indirect Speech
Ma mère me demande « Qu'est-ce que tu vois dans cet homme ? » My mother asks me, "What do you see in this man?"	Ma mère me demande ce que je vois dans cet homme. My mother asks me what I see in this man.
Luc demande à sa femme « Qu'est-ce que tu veux boire ? » Luc asks his wife, "What do you want to drink?"	Luc demande à sa femme ce qu'elle veut boire. Luc asks his wife what she wants to drink.

Modifications of Time Indicators

In indirect speech, the indicators of time (like aujourd'hui, demain, etc.) also change.

Direct Speech	Indirect Speech
aujourd'hui	ce jour-là
demain	le lendemain
hier	la veille
jour/année/semaine prochain(e)	jour/année/semaine suivant(e)

Direct Speech	Indirect Speech
Lucie pensait : « Je vais faire les courses aujourd'hui. » Lucie thought, "I'm going shopping today."	Lucie pensait qu'elle allait faire les courses ce jour-là. Lucie thought she was going shopping that day.
Elle m'a dit : « Ton visa sera prêt demain. » She said to me, "Your visa will be ready tomorrow."	Elle m'a dit que mon visa serait prêt le lendemain. She said to me that my visa would be ready the next day
Le commerçant a dit : « Les courses ont été livrées hier. » The shopkeeper said, "The groceries were delivered yesterday"	Le commerçant a dit que les courses avaient été livrées la veille. The shopkeeper said the groceries were delivered the day before
Le professeur a annoncé : « Vous aurez des examens mardi prochain. » The professor announced, "You'll have exams next Tuesday."	Le professeur a annoncé que nous aurions des examens le mardi suivant. The professor announced that we would have exams on the following Tuesday.

Creative Conversion:

Direct - Indirect speech conversion need not always be word-to-word. Sometimes, we can add conjunctions and connectors to help transition the indirect speech to make sense. It also helps in writing actual reports/essays/fait divers.

Let's take an example:

Enseignante : Savez-vous lire le français ?

Étudiante : Non, Madame, je trouve le français très difficile.

Enseignante : Pourquoi ?

Étudiante : La grammaire est compliquée et les orthographes sont bizarres !

Enseignante : Ben, je suis là pour t'aider.

Indirect Speech:
L'enseignante demande si l'étudiante sait lire le français. L'étudiante répond que non, qu'elle trouve le français très difficile. L'enseignante demande pourquoi. L'étudiante explique que la grammaire est compliquée et que les orthographes sont bizarres. L'enseignante lui assure qu'elle est là pour l'aider.